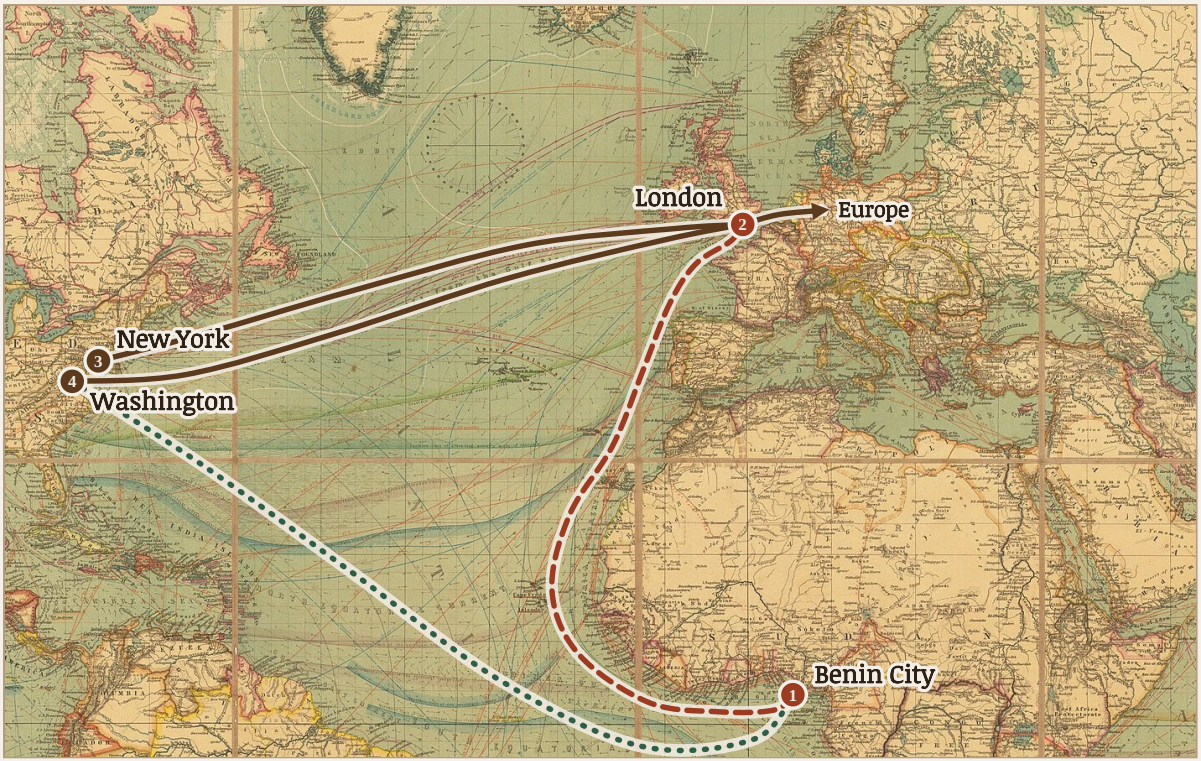
From Benin City to the world



1897 · Taken from ① Benin City to ② London, where many were auctioned

After 1897 · Sold on to collections in Europe and North America, among them ③ the Met and ④ the Smithsonian

2022 · The Smithsonian transfers ownership of 29 objects back to Nigeria

From Benin City to the world (map)

Map: Hermann Berghaus, Chart of the World on Mercator's Projection, Gotha: Justus Perthes, 1897 · Detail

A world map printed in the year of the raid, with the objects' journeys drawn on for this exhibition. Objects taken from Benin City were auctioned in London and passed to collections across Europe and North America. More than a century later, most of them are still outside Nigeria.

Map: public domain, via Wikimedia Commons (from Barry Lawrence Ruderman Antique Maps).